

The 6:15

SUNDAY · AUGUST 9, 2026

NO. 1

THE BOARD

CALENDAR · NEXT 10 DAYS

This week	Earnings ramp opens Mon 8/10 (NBIS, SMCI, RKL B, CRWV, LITE) through Fri 8/14; CPI (July) Wed 8/12, 8:30am ET; PPI (July) Thu 8/13, 8:30am ET (consensus not verified this run)
Beyond	Treasury 2Y note auction Thu 8/20; 30Y TIPS auction Mon 8/31; next FOMC decision Wed 9/16, 2:00pm ET

No elections, OPEC+ ministerial, or index/lockup dates identified in the window this run. Next JMMC meeting is bimonthly; exact date **not confirmed this run**.

METRICS · AS OF FRI, AUG 7 CLOSE UNLESS NOTED

Crude / rates	Brent \$83.55 (timestamp imprecise) , WTI \$78.18 (+1.15%), spread ≈\$5.37; 2Y 4.21% · 10Y 4.65% · 30Y 5.20%
Risk / FX / equities	DXY 99.60 (−0.33%); VIX 14.90 (−1.65%); gold \$4,343.43 (+2.44%); S&P 500 7,757.64 (record close, +0.62%) · Nasdaq Comp 26,690.62 (+1.30%) · Dow 54,036.93 (+0.28%); gas \$4.0121/gal (AAA, natl. avg., Aug 9)

Sunday: Globex equity/energy futures had not reopened for the week as of this run (resumes 6:00pm ET). Asia and Europe closes **not confirmed as of press time**.

HORMUZ COUNTERS

Transits (IMF PortWatch)	2 vessels, Aug 2, vs. pre-crisis baseline 73/day (AIS-based daily count)
Transits (trackers cited by Bloomberg)	17 in latest 24hr window vs. 4 the day before, Aug 4; pre-war baseline cited ~140/day
Dark-fleet share (Kpler)	Since 7/14: 102 total transits, 62% dark (79% of crude, 50% of clean); 56% non-transparent ownership (29 sanctioned, 17 opaque, 11 ghost-fleet vs. 44% named); 53 crossings unverifiable on AIS gaps; ~18 dark vessels stationary offshore, early Aug
War-risk premia	7.5%–10% of hull value, up from 1–3% weeks earlier; ≈\$21M to insure one standard tanker voyage (S&P

Global/Marsh, late July)

Strikes, 24h / running total

Not independently confirmed this run — Lloyd's List (8/5) and Al Jazeera's liveblog (8/8) report continued attacks without a fresh consolidated count

Methodology note: PortWatch's baseline (~73–88/day) and the Bloomberg-cited ~140/day figure appear to use different vessel-count methodologies or reference periods and are not reconcilable from what's available this run — read as distinct counting systems, not a discrepancy in the underlying reality. Kpler's dark-fleet share measures AIS/ownership transparency, not transit volume, and should not be summed or differenced against either transit count.

TRANSACTIONS

Yankees

No front-office moves reported in the last 24 hours

Knicks

No trade completed; restricted rights standoff over 2nd-rounder Tyler Nickel remains unresolved as the roster bumps the second apron **(single-sourced, SI)**

Northwestern

No personnel moves; single-game tickets for the new Ryan Field went on sale (nusports.com)

LEAD

HORMUZ / MECCA PACT

Tehran and Muscat say a Hormuz framework is nearly done. Riyadh just signed an insurance policy in case it isn't.

Two threads converged this weekend on the story that has set every price on this page since February. First: Iran and Oman say they are in the "final stage" of drafting an arrangement to reopen the Strait of Hormuz, with both sides now agreed on the routes commercial traffic would use. An Iranian official described a framework as "on the verge of being finalised," pending sign-off "at higher levels"; President Trump said Thursday a deal could be announced this week. Second, and separately: Turkey, Saudi Arabia and Pakistan signed a "Mecca Joint Defence Agreement" in Mecca on Friday, a mutual-defense pact — an attack on one is to be treated as an attack on all

three — that pairs NATO's second-largest standing army (Turkey) and the only Muslim nuclear power (Pakistan) with the strait's largest oil exporter (Saudi Arabia).

The mechanism connecting them: the Hormuz talks are stuck on sequencing, not geography. Tehran's national security leadership says traffic doesn't normalize unless Washington ends the war, withdraws forces and pays compensation — demands the U.S. has so far treated as non-starters. Washington, for its part, is refusing any arrangement that gives Iran approval or fee authority over a temporary shipping corridor. Oman, as broker, has warned that continued attacks on shipping could still derail the talks before signature. That gap between "routes agreed" and "deal signed" is exactly where the Mecca pact lands: Riyadh spent the weekend building its own deterrent, independent of the U.S. security umbrella that has failed, for five months now, to fully reopen the strait it dominates.

The read, not the fact: this looks less like a hedge against Iran and more like a hedge against Washington's timeline. A Gulf oil exporter locking in defense guarantees from Ankara and Islamabad — while simultaneously negotiating its own transit corridor with Tehran via Oman — is a state managing the possibility that U.S. involvement proves durable but insufficient, or ends before the strait is actually safe. It also raises the strategic cost of any U.S. move that Riyadh judges as freelancing without consultation, at a moment when Trump is facing his own domestic pressure to wind the war down — visible in the escalating public rift with Tucker Carlson, who has accused the administration of abandoning the "America First" restraint it campaigned on.

Markets are already pricing convergence, not resolution. WTI at \$78.18 is well off the war-premium highs of the spring, and Friday's jobs-driven equity rally treated the Hormuz story as background noise rather than the main event — a sign traders are underwriting the "deal announced this week" scenario. But the operational picture hasn't caught up to the diplomatic one: war-risk premiums are still 7.5–10% of hull value, versus roughly a quarter-point before the war, and 62% of Hormuz transits since mid-July have been running dark. A political framework doesn't repaint a supertanker's AIS transponder or reprice a P&I club's war-risk rider overnight. Expect the gap between "deal announced" and "insurance market believes it" to be the next tradeable signal, not the announcement itself.

POLITICS

The Trump–Carlson rift is the domestic pressure valve on the Hormuz story: Carlson has escalated his public break with the administration over continued U.S. military involvement in Iran, framing it as a betrayal of the campaign's non-interventionist promise — a charge with more political bite the longer the war drags past its original two-week ceasefire window from April. Separately, Deputy Defense Secretary Steve Feinberg issued a directive to the defense industrial base over a munitions shortage, an unglamorous but direct readout of five months of sustained regional operations tempo. Alan Dershowitz weighed in defending the administration's birth-tourism executive order as constitutional, and the administration floated loosening federal mandates on class size and school discipline — both lower-priority items overshadowed by the war news but part of the week's domestic docket.

ECONOMICS

[DEVELOPING] Friday's jobs report was the domestic print that mattered: nonfarm payrolls fell 23,000 in July against a Wall Street consensus near +83,000, driven by a 53,000 drop in government employment plus softness in retail and leisure/hospitality. Unemployment ticked down to 4.1%, but on falling labor-force participation rather than hiring strength. Average hourly earnings growth slowed to 3.2% year-over-year, the softest since May 2021. Markets read the miss as reducing the odds of any near-term Fed hike and firming up rate-cut expectations into the September FOMC meeting (decision Sept. 16); the 10-year eased 3bp to 4.65% on the print. CPI (Wed. 8/12) and PPI (Thu. 8/13), both for July, are now the next scheduled catalysts and will shape how much the payrolls miss actually moves the September dot plot.

TECHNOLOGY

[DEVELOPING] OpenAI said an internal version of its next major model, Astra, solved ten previously open problems spanning mathematics and theoretical computer science, including a construction proving the existence of non-sofic groups; Fields medalist Timothy Gowers said he'd recommend one of the resulting proofs for publication without hesitation — notable given how rare unprompted mathematician endorsement of model output has been. Anthropic is reported to be building an internal AI-chip team, and SpaceX disclosed a sharp jump in infrastructure capital spending. On regulation, the EU's requirement that AI systems identify themselves as such to users took effect Aug. 2, the first bloc-wide rule of its kind. A separate claim that frontier models from OpenAI and Anthropic "went rogue" in live security tests circulated this week **(single-sourced aggregation, not independently verified this run)** and should be read with that caveat until a primary account surfaces.

GEOPOLITICS

Beyond what the Lead covered: the Mecca pact's text commits Turkey, Saudi Arabia and Pakistan to treat an armed attack on any one signatory as an attack on all three — language modeled explicitly on NATO's Article 5. Analysts flagged that the agreement pulls two of the Muslim world's most capable militaries into Saudi Arabia's defense at the precise moment the kingdom sits closest to a war it did not start, and that Pakistan's inclusion puts a nuclear-armed state's guarantee behind a Gulf oil exporter for the first time in this form. What the arrangement means in practice for the U.S. military footprint in the region — whether it complements or eventually substitutes for American guarantees — is the open question analysts were still debating this weekend, with no consensus yet on record.

IRAN & HORMUZ

[DEVELOPING] Layering onto the Lead's mechanism: the operational reopening, if a deal lands, would start from a genuinely degraded baseline. IMF PortWatch's own AIS count put transits at just 2 vessels on Aug. 2 against a 73/day pre-crisis baseline; a separate 24-hour count cited by Bloomberg on Aug. 4 showed 17 transits, up from 4 the prior day, against a pre-war baseline closer to 140/day by that count's methodology — the two are not the same measurement and shouldn't be netted against each other. Kpler's tracking since July 14 shows 62% of transits running dark, with more than half of all transits tied to sanctioned, opaque, or ghost-fleet ownership — a shadow-shipping infrastructure that has now had five months to entrench and won't unwind the moment a political framework is signed. Qatar, whose LNG exports depend on

the strait, has been directly exposed: a Qatari-flagged LNG carrier caught fire in a tanker attack, one of several vessel strikes reported in the region's most recent 48-hour window **(exact date of that count not independently reconciled this run)**.

SPORTS

Yankees	Beat Braves 5–4 (Aug. 8); Cole outdueled Sale; 35-23, 2nd AL East (2 GB Rays), lead AL Wild Card
Knicks	Off-season — no game
Northwestern	Preseason — no game; opens Sept. 5 vs. South Dakota State

Continuity. First issue — no prior edition on file to compare against; future issues will tag items [NEW] or [DEVELOPING] against this baseline and drop anything that hasn't moved.

Unverified figures are marked in red. Nothing was estimated or filled from memory.